said: ‘A culpable Modi becomes the new inspiration for the BJP even as this offends the allies, infuriates the Opposition and divides the nation.’ After almost three decades in public life, the organizational man turned television spokesperson turned chief minister was now a national figure. An RSS pracharak who was once accused of lacking a mass base, who had only fought his first election earlier that year, finally had an identity.

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Modi’s victory in 2002 gave him the chance to establish himself as the Supreme Leader of Gujarat. He did not squander it. Over the next few years, he set about systematically decimating all opposition within and outside the BJP. The ageing Keshubhai Patel was confined to the occasional rumbling at being sidelined. Suresh Mehta, another former chief minister, was too gentle to offer any real threat. Kashiram Rana, a former state BJP president, was denied a Lok Sabha ticket. Gordhan Zadaphia, who was minister of state for home during the riots and was close to Togadia, was forced out of the party and eventually formed his own group. ‘Modi is the ultimate dictator—he will not tolerate anyone even questioning his decisions or leadership,’ Zadaphia once told me. Ironically, just before the 2014 elections, Zadaphia returned to the BJP and was forced to publicly acknowledge Modi as his leader.

Even Togadia, who had played a crucial role as a rabble-rouser during the 2002 elections, was completely marginalized. Modi even went to the extent of razing roadside temples in Gandhinagar built by local VHP karyakartas, if only to send out the message that he wasn’t going to do any special favours to the VHP for supporting him. Senior VHP leader Ashok Singhal likened Modi to Mahmud Ghazni for the demolition—ironical, since the rise of Modi had begun in 1990 during the rath yatra from Somnath to Ayodhya. Years later, an incensed Togadia told me in an interview, ‘We have nothing to do with Modi. He may be Gujarat’s chief minister, we stand for all Hindus!’